TOPIC SENTENCES

Usually the first sentence of a paragraph in the body of an essay is a topic sentence.

The topic sentence tells the purpose of the paragraph and connects the paragraph to the thesis.

The topic sentence has three parts:

- A transition indicates the idea in the paragraph is one of several supporting the thesis.
- A reminder of the thesis connects the paragraph to the purpose of the paper.
- The main idea of the sentence tells the main idea of the paragraph.

WRITING THE TOPIC SENTENCE

1. Think before you begin. Ask yourself: What do I want to discuss in the paragraph?
2. Before you begin the paragraph, jot down some ideas and develop a list of what you want to discuss in the paragraph. Look over the list and determine which ideas belong together, and which should be saved for another paragraph. Then plan a topic sentence that is suitable for the list you have developed.
3. Check that your topic sentence clearly covers the specifics you will discuss in your paragraph.
4. As you are writing your paragraph, and after you have finished it, check your topic sentence again:
    - Is it focused on one main idea?
    - Does it clearly state what you intend to discuss?
    - Has your paragraph been properly limited and controlled by your topic sentence?
    - If you see a problem with what you have written, revise your topic sentence or revise your paragraph, which ever seems better.
5. Check that your topic sentence has all three parts:
    - a transition,
    - a reminder of the thesis,
    - the main idea – the purpose of the paragraph.

See reverse side - Identifying the Parts of a Topic Sentence

Dr. Rodney

When a person thinks of that old-time, small-town doctor he usually envisions a mannerly, dignified gentleman. However this image did not fit my Uncle Rodney, a doctor in the small town of Bandon, Wyoming. Instead, Doctor Rodney was an obnoxious person because he had an annoying habit of speaking in crude, incoherent sentences; he had sloppy eating habits; and he was a messy smoker.

Probably Doctor Rodney's most irritating trait was his crude way of speaking. For example, I recall a particularly embarrassing moment during a family reunion at my mother-in-law's house when Dr Rodney was asked to say a blessing before dinner. He managed a “Hump, bump, grump," or so it sounded, and almost immediately added "Goddammit" as he knocked over a bowl of grated corn he was grabbing. As a result, my mother-in-law – a very religious person – was mortified. On another occasion, Dr. Rodney's nurse said, "It's a good thing I can interpret what Dr. Rodney says and smooth over the rough feelings, or we would be out of patients."

Additionally, Doctor Rodney bothered many people with his messy eating habits. He shoveled food into his mouth at such an alarming rate that often he could not catch his breath. My brother- in-law once remarked, "When I see Uncle Rodney eat I think of jackals devouring their kill." Furthermore, Doctor Rodney always finished his meal long before anyone else; then he would make a nauseating slurping sound by sucking air and saliva through the gaps between his top front teeth while he waited for everybody else to finish. Because of his atrocious eating habits, none of Doctor Rodney's neighbors invited him to dinner.

Doctor Rodney was also disliked because he was an inconsiderate smoker. Everywhere he went, he left a trail of ashes, a terrible stench, and wet, chewed-up cigar butts. After his death, the office cleaning lady confided that the townspeople used to bet on how many days would pass before anyone saw Dr. Rodney without a spot of tobacco juice in his shirt. Naturally, all the local children learned not to be downwind from him because no one could easily tolerate his odor of stale tobacco.

Clearly, Dr. Rodney was an obnoxious person whose talking, eating, and smoking habits alienated him from even his own family. He was indeed lucky that the town had only one doctor, or he might not have been employed.

Identifying the Parts of a Topic Sentence

Thesis: “Instead, Doctor Rodney was an obnoxious person because he had an annoying habit of speaking in crude, incoherent sentences; he had sloppy eating habits; and he was a messy smoker.”

The parts of the topic sentence in the second paragraph are:

- Transition: The word "most" tells the reader that the first of several reasons will be presented in this paragraph.
- Reminder of the Thesis: The words, "irritating trait," repeat the idea of the thesis that Doctor Rodney is obnoxious.
- Main Idea of Paragraph: The paragraph will focus on "his crude way of speaking."

The parts of the topic sentence in the third paragraph are:

- Transition: "Additionally" suggests that this paragraph will discuss another reason that supports the thesis.
- Reminder of the Thesis: "Doctor Rodney bothered many people" connects to the thesis word "obnoxious."
- Main Idea of Paragraph: "his messy eating habits" tells the reader the subject of this paragraph.

The parts of the topic sentence in the fourth paragraph are:

- Transition: "Also" indicates that the third supporting idea will be explained in this paragraph.
- Reminder of the Thesis: "was also disliked" repeats the idea of the thesis.
- Main Idea of Paragraph: This paragraph is about how Doctor Rodney is an "inconsiderate smoker."

Go back to the topic sentences in the second, third, and fourth paragraphs of this essay and underline each transition, circle each reminder of thesis, and box each main idea of the paragraphs.